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Knowing what's right doesn't mean much unless you do what's right.
— Theodore Roosevelt

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IN 1932
BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

US sanctions policy is reckless and blunt

IN THE aftermath of the US Congress passing the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Bill, there is understandable concern — and consternation — about its effect on India's energy security, one of its most consequential bilateral ties and the principle of strategic autonomy that animates New Delhi's foreign policy. The Bill empowers the White House to impose up to 100 per cent tariffs on countries importing Russian oil and is targeted at India and China. In terms of principles and strategy, it is flawed. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's assertion of India's right to "ensure energy security for its 1.4 billion people", and his warning that the weaponisation of the Graham Bill against India could have "potential consequences" for India-US ties is, therefore, appropriate.

The Bill shows that the Donald Trump administration hasn't learnt the lessons from Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA). Passed in 2017, that law too sought to impose sanctions on the US's "adversaries". Nearly a decade later, many of those adversaries are engaged in wars on two continents. In addition to the direct devastation in West Asia and Eastern Europe, these conflicts have disrupted supply chains, escalated energy insecurity and made the global order more unstable. Delhi's deft diplomacy and better sense in Washington ensured that an exception was carved out under CAATSA for India's purchase of the S-400 missile defence system from Russia. India's current stance, framed by EAM Jaishankar, also leaves room for accommodation without compromising on core issues. Much will now depend on behind-the-scenes diplomacy.

Much of the world, including India, had no part in creating the conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia. The Trump administration, which rode to power on a plank of ending America's "forever wars", cannot evade complicity in the deepening of the West Asia crisis. Dissonance between principles and practice is, of course, a part of global realpolitik, especially when it comes to superpowers. But that practicality cuts both ways. The White House's special envoys visited Russia to try to end the conflict in Ukraine. A substantial portion of Europe's energy needs are met by Russian gas, with no talk of sanctions. The Graham Bill may well be a pressure tactic —to nudge Russia towards a peace deal, and India, a trade agreement — but it is a blunt instrument. As choked energy supplies threaten to snowball into steep price rises in the US, the Trump administration, which faces crucial mid-term elections, may want to be seen as trying to act tough against Russia. But shifting the blame onto countries like India could prove counterproductive. Middle powers do need to find ways to navigate this geoeconomic churn. But Washington's blinkered vision could lead to a loss of trust in the US.

Ensure dignity, way back for Manipur's displaced

THE SUPREME Court's expression of shock over reports of deaths, including unnatural ones, in relief camps for internally displaced people (IDPs) in Manipur should be an eye-opener for the Centre and the state government. It raises the larger question about what prolonged stays in these camps do to people, who have nowhere else to go. The IDPs remain trapped in a crisis that has been intractable for over three years. Continued displacement deepens vulnerabilities that extend beyond the loss of a home, particularly in access to healthcare.

Manipur's healthcare system is heavily concentrated in Imphal. The state's two tertiary government hospitals — the Jawaharlal Nehru Institute of Medical Sciences and the Regional Institute of Medical Sciences — are located in the capital. Once the violence-induced ethnic segregation set in, Kuki-Zo people from the hills could no longer travel to the Valley for treatment. Healthcare facilities in the hills lack specialists and essential equipment. An August 2023 report in this newspaper revealed that some patients had to seek healthcare outside Manipur — the closest destination being Aizawl, a journey of over 12 hours by road. Persistent blockades have compounded the crisis, affecting not only patients trying to reach hospitals but also the movement of medicines and medical personnel. By all accounts, the food provided in many camps is nutritionally deficient.

What was meant to be a temporary refuge has left thousands of people dependent on an inadequate and fragile healthcare system. Earlier this month, the Manipur government told the state Assembly that the number of IDPs in relief camps and temporary locations had come down to 28,899, from nearly 60,000 at the peak of the violence. More needs to be done. For those still living in the camps, the state must ensure adequately staffed medical facilities at or near the camps, along with supplies of medicines and other essential services. Without a durable solution to the Meitei-Kuki conflict — which has increasingly acquired a Naga-Kuki dimension as well — the conditions for a safe and sustainable rehabilitation will remain elusive. Dialogue and confidence-building measures must pave the way for a political settlement that ends the violence and allows displaced people to rebuild their lives with security and dignity.

At Asiad, all that glitters isn't gold

ONE IN every five athletes, among 500 Indians who have landed in Aichi-Nagoya for the Asian Games, could return with a medal. The count could exceed that of the Hangzhou Games. But all that glitters is not likely to be gold. Medals, no doubt, are important. But more significant would be the field in which they are won.

India's ambition to be a sporting superpower rests not only on the number of medals or their placement on the table, but also on the events in which its athletes break fresh ground. It would be mildly exciting if the cricket teams defend their gold medal. Such is their monopoly on the sport that it could not count as upward mobility. As would be a clutch of other streams the country has traditionally dominated — like shooting or kabaddi.

A better indicator of India's sustained rise would be winning medals in sports where the competition is intense and where the country's athletes have historically struggled. Weightlifting is a good example. Mirabhai Chanu is an Olympic medallist, and one of the country's finest athletes. But she has not stood on the Asiad podium in two shots. The lone gold medal bagged by India's shuttlers came in 2022, thanks to the men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty. The country's archers have also had middling outcomes. A gold has eluded the country in wrestling since 2018. More gold medals in athletics will be welcome. At Aichi-Nagoya, the quality of silverware will matter.

Graham Bill is America confusing its power with virtue — yet again



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

THE GRAHAM Bill, targeting India and China for oil purchases from Russia, is a grotesque exercise in selectively applying international morality. The problem with the Bill is not just that it targets third countries with sanctions. It is that it once again enacts American imperial privilege. Even if you believe that Russia is the aggressor in Ukraine and the mistakes of the West do not justify, in any measure, Russia's casus belli; even if you have no sympathy for Iran's regime; even if you think China and India should play a different and more proactive role in ending the wars in Russia and Ukraine, you should find the Graham Bill obscene.

The most disconcerting part of the Bill is what it puts on full display about American democracy. The war on Iran is unpopular in the US. Criticism of Donald Trump's conduct of the war is quite vocal. The war has caused immeasurable disruption to the global economic system. Its secondary security and political effects are playing out, plunging an entire region into instability and conflict. Yet, the American political system does not seem to have the means to hold its own President accountable for these consequences. It is a pathetic attempt to convert the failure of democratic accountability at home into a form of imperial privilege over the rest of the world.

The fact that this is being done with bipartisan consensus is an indictment of American democracy. The US Congress sees it as fit to discipline other countries, who were never consulted about the conduct of war, more than it does to hold its own executive accountable. Congressional abdication in the conduct of the Iran war has been apparent from day one. Trump, the individual, may be an aberration. But the caprice and conceit of executive power in the US is not. America has been conducting wars by the nihilism of executive fiat. Congress just strengthened it. In doing so, it also put a question mark on its own representative status, in letting down the American people. By externalising the blame for the war in Ukraine onto India and China without corresponding pressure on Trump to end at least the one war he can easily end — Iran — American democracy has dealt a blow to itself.

The US, in contravention of all international decency, claims the authority to punish any third country that had no role in starting the war, that is not consulted in the conduct of the war, and bears the collateral costs of the war. But it leaves the US and its own conduct of actual war outside of the framework of any accountability. The Bill seeks to preserve exemptions for the US's imports of low-enriched uranium, as if the US cannot bear the cost of those import restrictions, while poor countries around the world are expected to put up with rising energy costs. There is a kind of shamelessness here that is astonishing. But the Europeans have been equally selective in where they seek to apply principles of international law, privileging the war in Ukraine over other wars, including Iran.

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Senator J William Fulbright had made famous the phrase "Arrogance of Power" as a characterisation of American foreign policy. The arrogance was at many different levels. America confused its power with its own virtue. American power always acts as if it is self-legitimating; only others need to account for themselves. American power can carve out exceptions for itself. And its excessive pride will never prompt it to move to self-restraint or even admit defeat for the sake of peace. American power also translates into epistemic delusions about how the rest of the world actually functions.

The Graham Bill is nothing but a legislative imprimatur on this arrogance of power. But it is also deeply delusional. It displays the classic mistake of thinking that America can, in the final analysis, determine the political choices of large countries. Ukraine and Iran have shown why the practice of sovereignty still matters. The US will not achieve global stability by arm-twisting major powers like China and India through the threat of sanctions. If anything, Congress should be censuring Trump for his failures. It would also do well to remember Fulbright's words: "When we violate the law ourselves, whatever short-term advantage may be gained, we are obviously encouraging others to violate the law; we thus encourage disorder and instability and thereby do incalculable damage to our own long-term interests."

This column has argued that the initial strategy of trying to placate America was a big mistake. A closer America-India relationship is a desirable outcome. But to fail to learn the lessons about the imperial and arbitrary conduct of the American executive, now implicitly ratified by Congress, was delusional. This is something the American lobby in India fails to acknowledge. It pathologises criticism of the American state as anger, not as a matter of principle. More deeply, even in our response, we have failed to articulate the principles at stake. We have said *ad nauseam*, at a high level of abstraction, that this is not the era of war. In the Ministry of External Affairs' response, we have drawn the bright line that the well-being of 1.4 billion people cannot be held hostage to American whims. But our response is weakened by two things. The first is a strong counter-discourse that we need to keep offering concessions to stay in the game in Washington and calibrate our position to not draw Trump's ire. The second is the inability to plainly name the violation of principles at stake in all these wars — Ukraine, Gaza, now in Iran, and the wider region.

Strategic autonomy requires having to go beyond a pinched-up and narrow conception of our interests. Placating the US with tactical accommodation will be a sign of weakness. We should not enact a weaker version of the narcissism of American power than Congress has just confirmed.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

Punjab owes its young a chance to recover



MANPREET BADAL

OVER 10 lakh people in Punjab have registered at government de-addiction clinics since the state opened them — that is only those who gave their names. First, let us shed the delusion that Punjab was a pure land into which drugs were smuggled by strangers. *Afeem* (opium) has been in this soil for two 100 years. Our grandfathers took it at weddings and at funerals. Our farmers took it to get through the harvest. Our soldiers took it to battle. *Bhukki* (poppy husk) was sold at the village shop, and nobody thought it was the end of civilisation. We were never a society devoid of intoxicants. However, we were a society with boundaries and rules. What has changed and blurred these boundaries is not our morals. It is the chemistry.

I am neither a doctor nor a scientist, but I have spoken to several. Here is the crucial element of addiction that is rarely explained, and it matters more than any sermon. Opium and heroin act on the same receptor in the brain. The difference is speed. Opium eaten is absorbed over hours — a slow rise and a body that can argue with it. Heroin smoked or injected reaches the brain in seconds. It is the rate of the rise, not the substance itself, that burns a person's craving.

That is why *afeem* produced old men with a habit while *chitta* sends boys to graveyards.

The brain has its own opioids — the chemistry that lets you bear pain, feel pleasure, sleep, hold a conversation. When a stronger drug floods those receptors every day, the brain stops making its own. Within months, the body is no longer chasing a high. It is chasing a normal. Withdrawal doesn't just mean discomfort. It is a body that has lost the ability to feel ordinary comfort. Which is why the word "willpower" is the single most useless word in this debate. You may as well ask a man with a broken femur to walk it off.

Why Punjab? We have taken risks. We have always sent our young men to do dangerous things a long way from home — to the Ghadar movement, Flanders, Kohima, the Line of Control, oil rigs, highways, and now to Brampton. Restlessness is not a defect in the Punjabi character. It is the engine of it.

Give a 20-year-old built for risk nothing worth risking, no work, no field of his own, no rank to earn, no team to belong to, and that appetite does not disappear. It goes looking. And there is always somebody at the edge of the village willing to sell something.

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We moralise about this because moralising is free. Governing is not. So let me be specific about what governing would look like.

On supply, the border is not a slogan; it is an engineering problem. These molecules are now potent enough that a year's worth of them crosses in a drone the size of a tiffin box. No amount of seizures will outrun that arithmetic. What works is technology on the fence, detection grids, counter-drone systems, forensics that trace a consignment backwards and the political will to prosecute the men who protect the trade rather than the boys who consume it. Every government of every colour has arrested peddlers. Not one has broken a network.

I was finance minister when Punjab built the Outpatient Opioid Assisted Treatment programme. I signed the cheques for it, and I will say plainly that we built the frame and then starved it. Today we can tell you how many crore tablets were dispensed last year. We cannot tell you how many people recovered. We are counting pills instead of counting lives. And a tablet worth thirty rupees at the clinic sells for three hundred outside it, which tells you exactly how much supervision we are paying for.

We need more money, yes. And I mean money of an order that would embarrass this state's present priorities. The entire de-addiction budget is a rounding error on our power subsidy bill. Money needs to be spent on the parts that are empty — psychiatrists, of whom Punjab has a shameful handful, counsellors, hospital beds. Follow-ups are necessary — for every relapse happens 18 months after the last dose. And jobs, because a recovered boy with nothing to do on a Tuesday afternoon is not recovered.

This is not a moral emergency. It is a medical condition, with a criminal supply chain, sitting on top of a governance failure. Each of those three has a known solution, and all three cost money and attention that we have chosen to spend elsewhere.

A boy addicted to drugs can recover. That is the fact nobody says that loudly enough. His brain heals, slowly, imperfectly, but it heals. Ten lakh families in this state are waiting to find out whether we care enough to help it along.

The writer is former finance minister of Punjab and national vice president, BJP

Don't force soldiers to fight for their due



MANMOHAN BAHADUR

A RECENT court judgment concerning disparity of pay and pension amongst certain ranks, and subsequent government action, has called into question the executive's approach in resolving issues that concern the armed forces. All opinion polls show that the Indian armed forces stand at the top in terms of the common man's belief in terms of probity — and of course, love and affection. It thus comes as a surprise that the government, irrespective of the party in power, sometimes engages in a confrontational way with the soldier. The bone of contention has often been the implementation of pay commission recommendations.

Pay commissions for central government employees are set up every 10 years. Unfortunately, almost every pay commission award has had to be contested by the services in terms of disparities vis-à-vis other services and insufficient recognition of the special conditions in which they operate. The Sixth Pay Commission introduced Military Service Pay up to brigadiers (and equivalent). This resulted in brigadiers getting more pay than major generals and a similar unacceptable anomaly in pensions as they retired. Some adversely affected generals (and equivalents in the other two services) went to court after the government failed to rectify this anomaly. The Armed Forces Tribunal (AFT) ruled in their favour in March 2023. However, the government did not implement the ruling despite the AFT's execution orders. It challenged the award in the Delhi High Court, which admitted the plea but did not stay the AFT's ruling.

With no rectification in sight, 82 aggrieved officers filed contempt petitions in the HC. When the court issued contempt notices, orders were issued on August 31 to grant the raise plus arrears to only the 82 officers who had litigated. Now, there is a drive by many generals (and equivalents) to petition the judiciary for a similar ruling. Let this sink in: Two- and three-star officers, who spent their youth in the service of the nation and are now septuagenarians and octogenarians, plan to spend their time and money to ask the state for something already granted (and hence accepted as correct) to their compatriots. Two facts stare us in the face. One, the government knows that the disparity in pay and pensions came about after the Sixth Pay Commission, but has issued orders to rectify the anomalies of only the 82 officers who litigated. Two, the judiciary has acceded to the pleas of these 82 but has not expanded its ruling to cover all who are similarly placed. These facts point to three deductions.

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First, the government knows there are hundreds of other officers with the same grievance. So, a responsive executive should be duty-bound, to cover all other personnel affected; data for all is computerised and available in government records. Second, the judiciary could take *suo motu* cognisance of the anomaly and save the nation the needless spectacle of hundreds of officers going to court for something that has been ruled in favour of only some of their brother officers. Finally, in this era of returning to India's roots and wisdom, it would be wise to remember Kautilya, who said to the king of Magadha, "The day the soldier has to demand his dues will be a sad day for Magadha. From that day on, you will have lost all moral sanction to be king." This timeless adage of statecraft should be the driver for decision-making.

The writer is a retired air vice marshal

40 YEARS AGO
September 19, 1986


SAREES
INDIAN EXPRESS
PM gives Rs 684 cr for Bengal industry
Political overtones denied
12 killed in Lanka
India cautious over British proposals
French attache shot, two hurt in Lebanon

PM on Gorkhaland issue

THE PRIME Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, said there was no question of creating a separate Gorkhaland by dividing West Bengal. "No further amendment of the Constitution will be allowed for division of states," he declared. The Prime Minister said the examination of the speeches, letters, cassettes available on the Gorkha National Liberation Front-led movement revealed that it was not aimed at achieving statehood. "Their major demand is that citizens of Nepal crossing over to India should be accepted as Indian citizens."

India responds to Britain

INDIA WAS cautious in its response to the draft extradition treaty presented by Britain. A spokesman for the External Affairs Ministry would not comment on whether the British government's decision to have such a treaty amounted to a special concession. He hoped the British government would use the provision of its existing laws, its political will, as well as the executive powers at its command to deal with issues pertaining to terrorist activities directed against India.

12 killed in Sri Lanka

AT LEAST 12 civilians were shot dead and several wounded when security forces opened fire in Sri Lanka's eastern Batticaloa town, 303 km from Colombo, after five security personnel were injured in a car bomb explosion, Batticaloa Citizens' Committee sources said. Batticaloa general hospital confirmed that 12 bodies had been brought to the hospital and that all but two bore gunshot wounds

French attaché shot in Lebanon

A FRENCH military attaché was shot dead in Beirut and two French UN soldiers were wounded in a separate attack in south Lebanon, security sources said. The French Embassy said the attaché, Col Christian Gouttierre, had been killed but gave no details. The security sources said he died instantly after three unidentified gunmen fired at him in front of the embassy in the Christian East Beirut suburb of Mar Takla.